20

THE IPL

The Indian Premier League, the franchise-based Twenty20 competition that started in April 2008, has had a revolutionary impact on world cricket. It seems to have captured the imagination of the modern fan and has attracted the best players from around the world. I am convinced that the IPL will continue to be a permanent feature of the global cricket calendar, just as it has already become a part of Indian households every April and May.

Despite sometimes being played in rather adverse weather conditions and on occasions outside of India, most of the games have been played to sell-out crowds. And this is not restricted to the smaller venues. In May 2013, people came out in droves to support quality cricket, despite all the talk of spot- and match-fixing surrounding the tournament. I was disappointed, shocked and angry at the goings-on, and said so in a press release at the time. There has to be a complete zero-tolerance policy against corruption and more should be done to educate the players, but on the other hand the tournament as a whole cannot be blamed for the wrongdoings of a few.

There is little doubt that the IPL has added an entirely new dimension to Indian cricket. Not only has interest grown in domestic competitions, but there is also a spill-over effect that has helped improve general awareness about domestic cricket. It has certainly made domestic performances more significant, with players knowing that playing well on the domestic circuit may earn them an IPL contract.

Early fears